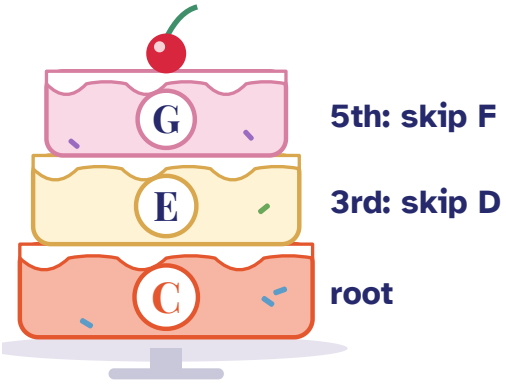
PART V · CHORDS · 1

Chords and triads

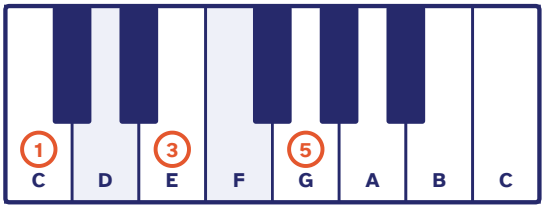
Press three or more notes at once and you have a **chord**. The favourite of all is the **triad**: three notes stacked like a layer cake.

THE SECRET

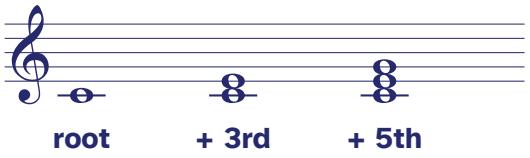
Play one, skip one, play one: the cake rule.



1. Pick a note: the **root**, the big layer at the bottom. It holds the chord up and gives it its name.
2. Skip one letter, take the next: **E**, the **3rd**.
3. Skip again: **G**, the **5th**. C E G is the triad of C.



On the keys: play one, skip one (shaded), play one, skip one, play one.



The cake on the staff: three lines in a row (or three spaces).

On the staff, each layer sits on the **next line up** (or the next space up): the root, a **3rd** above it, a **5th** above the root.

First met: Level ½ (the tonic triad of C, G and F major).

All lines or all spaces

A stacked triad sits on **three lines in a row** or in **three spaces in a row**, in a neat stack. If one note breaks the pattern, it is not a stacked triad.



Lines, spaces, lines, spaces: every one a triad.

PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

Solid and broken

Played together, a chord is **solid** (or blocked). Played one note at a time, it is **broken**. Spread up and down the keyboard, a broken chord becomes an **arpeggio**. Left-hand accompaniments, the arpeggios in technical work and the chord names over a song are all triads.

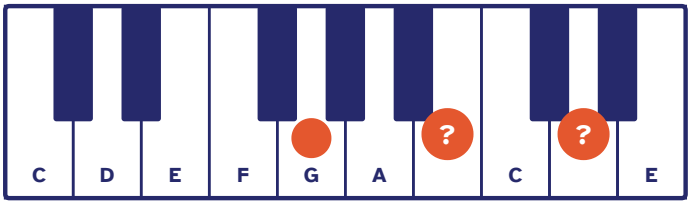
First met: Level 0; arpeggios from Level 1.



The same three notes, solid then broken.

EXAMPLE 1

Build a triad on G

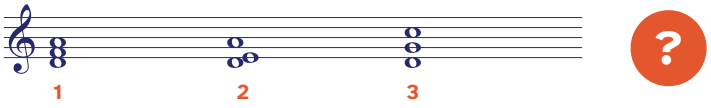


1. **Start on G** (the red dot): the root, the bottom layer.
2. **Skip one white key,** take the next: the first ?.
3. **Skip again,** take the next: the second ?.

G **B D**: the triad of **G**. Same shape as C E G, just moved up.

EXAMPLE 2

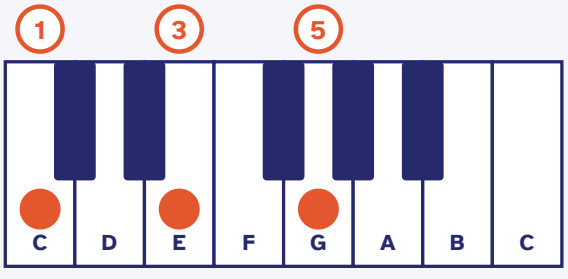
Which one is a triad?



1. **Look at each chord:** are the three notes all on lines, or all in spaces?
2. **Count the notes** from each note to the next one up: is every gap a 3rd?
3. **Only one chord** passes both tests. Which?

Chord 1 (D F A, three spaces in a row). Chord 2 has a 2nd (D–E); chord 3 is stacked in 4ths.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C. Fingers 1, 3, 5 down together.

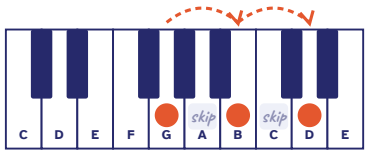
That is the C chord. Slide your hand to any white key and do it again: the cake shape always works.

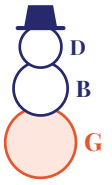
PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

Build one yourself

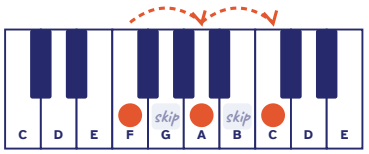
G

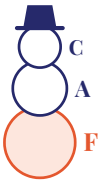




Start on G: **G B D**.

F

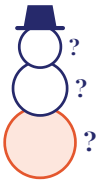




Start on F: **F A C**.
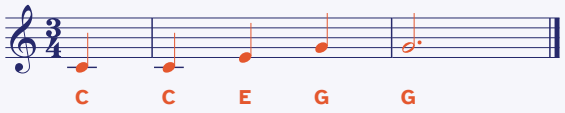
?





Your turn: start on **A**. Which three keys?

Build the cake on A: play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one.

Answer: A C E: the triad on A.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Blue Danube (Johann Strauss II), here in C



The most famous waltz tune simply climbs the **C triad**: **C, C E G, G**. Root, 3rd, 5th, then it holds the top: that is why it sounds so open.

Try it. Play C E G one at a time, then hum the waltz over it.

THINK OF IT Solid: three friends shout “Hello!” together. Broken: each says it in turn.

TRAP

- × Stacking 2nds or 4ths: a triad skips exactly one letter each time.
- × Naming a chord from its top note: the root names it (at the bottom when the notes are stacked in 3rds).

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 39 · Major scales p. 90

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 1 · Online: Library › Chords